

JCC: The Great War of Mahabharata - Kauravas

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Co-Chairs: Hrishi Bhooma & Sthavir Vinjamuri

Committee Directors: Abhiram Chavali & Arjun Garg

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Topic 1: Fighting Pandavas

Background:

The war at Kurukshetra is a culmination of various factors and conflicts that have developed over the years, all based around the central family dynamic of the Kauravas and the Pandavas. After King Pandu left the kingdom and his brother, the blind king Dhritarashtra, assumed the position, a dispute eventually arose over the right of Pandu's eldest son, Yudhishtira, to the throne. Dhritarashtra, influenced by his son Duryodhana, aimed to maintain control, and the Kauravas hatched a plot to kill the Pandavas through the burning of a flammable palace. The plot failed however, but the Pandavas were driven out for some time.

After Yudhishtira later attempted to establish his authority through the Rajasuya Yagya, Duryodhana and Shakuni invited him to a gambling match, in which the Pandavas lost their kingdom and were exiled for 12 years. After the exile, a compromise was attempted through the mediation of Krishna, but was shut down by Duryodhana, who refused to give the Pandavas land equal to even the tip of a needle. These conflicts between the two branches of the Kuru dynasty are ultimately what led to the start of the Kurukshetra war.

Current Situation:

Both sides assembled their own armies, and obtained the support of allied kingdoms. The Kaurava side maintains a vast numerical advantage, and has several accomplished and powerful military leaders, including Bhishma and Drona. However, much of the army is not directly associated with Hastinapura. Allies have various loyalties and motivations, and may be obligated to fight rather than willing. Proper leadership and cooperation are essential to keeping the Kaurava army in shape to defeat the Pandavas.

Additionally, the introduction of divine weapons creates an environment where the war can rapidly escalate, and they may become crucial to the development of the war. Early decisions will likely set expectations for the course of the war, determining whether it is shaped by traditional norms or increasingly destructive tactics. Krishna's support for the Pandavas also complicates the war, as the Kauravas not only have to contend with the Pandava army, but potential divine intervention.

Possible Solutions:

One avenue for the Kaurava army is simply to overwhelm the Pandava army through numbers, powerful divine weapons (astras), and effective military leadership. This is the clearest advantage the Kauravas have over the Pandavas, but while effective, may result in significant casualties and destruction for the kingdom.

In contrast, diplomacy is another feasible solution, and one that may still benefit the Kauravas. The Pandavas' compromise asked for only five villages, yet was rejected by Duryodhana. It is possible that negotiations can be made, but since the stage for battle is already set, it may require significant leverage to come to an agreement that benefits the Kaurava side.

Questions to Consider:

- What does victory mean for the Kauravas: destruction of the Pandavas, or kingdom control?
- Is it possible to negotiate and still have a positive result for the Kauravas, or is it too late?
- Should divine weapons be used as the battle continues? Is it an effective strategy as morale declines, or will increasing losses on both sides further demoralize troops?
- How can alliance support be maintained after early battlefield attacks?

Topic 2: Navigating Politics During the War

Background:

The Kauravas garner support from so many kingdoms, and they all have reasons for being involved. However, they might not support Hastinapura purely, and this could create bad situations. For instance, Shalya. His sister Madri was married to Pandu, which makes him the Pandavas' uncle. Now, he's fighting with his own nephews; this type of situation could cause more problems if not solved properly.

The politics within Hastinapura make these situations worse. Since King Dhritarashtra is blind and loves his sons very much, it's hard for him to make decisions when necessary. Also, Vidura vowed to stay neutral, meaning his wise counsel is not available. Gandhari blindfolded herself, alongside her husband, but she still has power because she is able to bless/curse. Her satisfaction is very important. Additionally, there is the bigger issue of legitimacy. Many people question whether the Kauravas are actually fit to rule. Diplomatic work must occur to deal with these internal problems and to show strength to the outside allies.

Current Situation:

The Kauravas bring kingdoms together with different levels of commitment. For instance, kings like Shalya, Bhagadatta, and Sudakshina command large armies, so they are very important to win the war. But, their loyalty relies on being treated properly, and their voices must be heard in important decisions. There are also divisions within the Kaurava family itself. Vikarna publicly spoke against the way his brothers treated Draupadi during the dice game, which shows that not everyone follows the Kaurava actions. There is a question of unity.

Throughout the war, there are ways to improve or damage the position of the Kauravas through diplomacy. There are neutral kingdoms who might be convinced to join if they are approached carefully/correctly. They might even be persuaded to stay neutral, meaning they won't help the Pandavas. Vidura still has influence despite his neutrality. Gandhari and Dushala also have political weight because of their positions and family connections. The Kauravas must work together to make post-war governance feasible.

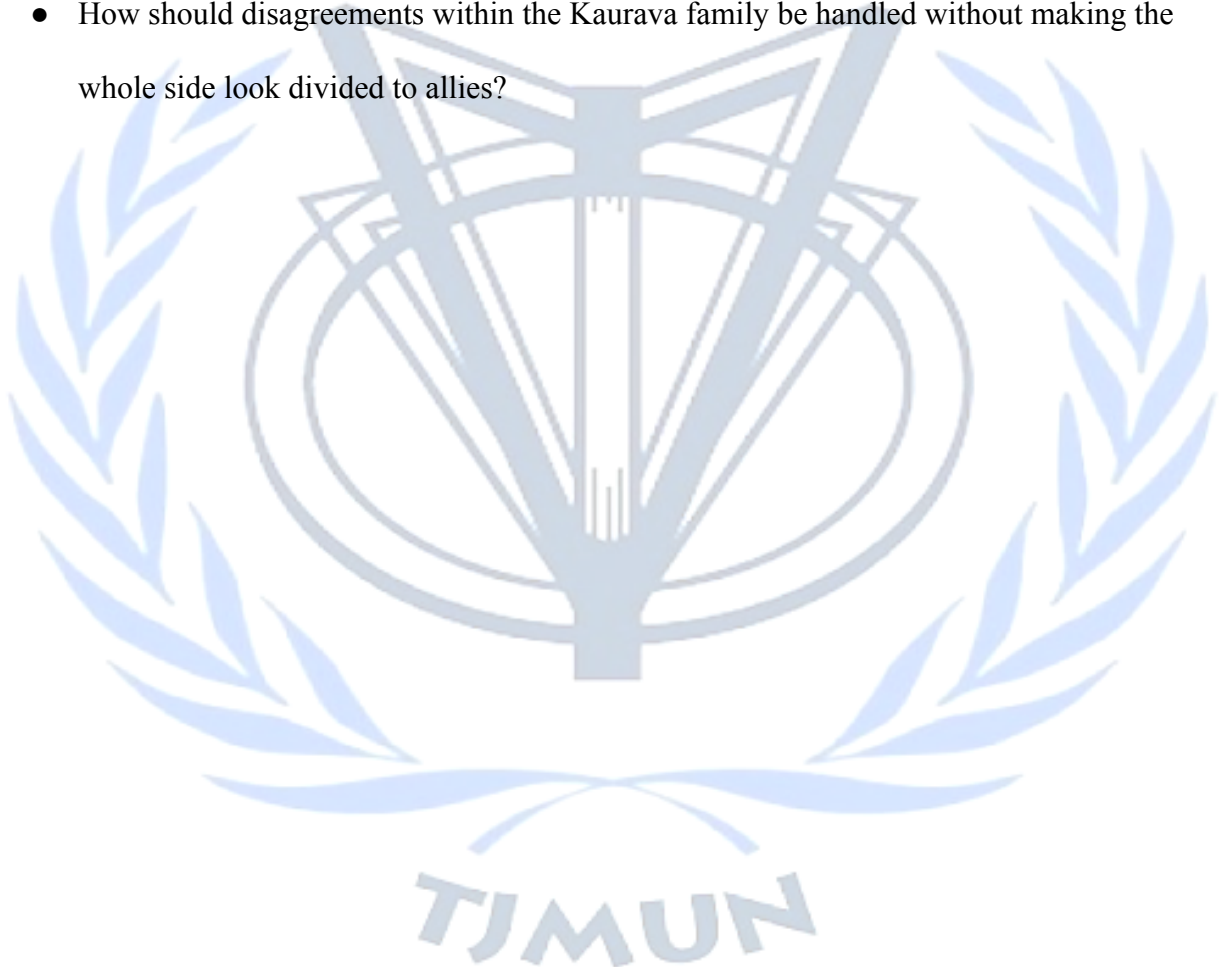
Possible Solutions:

Keeping the coalition together requires giving allied rulers real participation in decision-making. Setting up councils where kings like Shalya and Bhagadatta can share their views and help shape strategy prevents resentment from building up. When allies feel their input matters, they commit more fully to the cause. Assigning responsibilities to each kingdom based on what they do best demonstrates trust and creates shared investment in success. Holding regular meetings to discuss concerns and following through on promises helps maintain good relationships as the war continues.

The internal tensions in Hastinapura need direct attention as well. Gandhari's moral authority can be used to bless important military actions or warriors, which boosts morale and adds legitimacy to Kaurava decisions. Finding appropriate ways to include perspectives like Vikarna's prevents disagreements from turning into open splits within the family. Dushala's marriage connections can be used to strengthen ties with allied kingdoms through kinship bonds. Dhritarashtra should remain involved enough to preserve his authority as king, but actual strategic decisions need to come from people who can assess situations clearly. Getting this balance right prevents political dysfunction from undermining military effectiveness.

Questions to Consider:

- How can the Kauravas keep allied kingdoms committed when their rulers have different motivations for fighting?
- What political concessions or rewards might be needed to hold the coalition together as the war continues?
- How should disagreements within the Kaurava family be handled without making the whole side look divided to allies?



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JCC: The Great War of Mahabharata - Kauravas - Dossier

Dhritarashtra (dhri-tha-raash-tra)

The blind king of Hastinapura, wed to Gandhari, who has extraordinary physical strength as a compensatory divine boon. As a mostly non-participant of the Kurukshetra, Dhritarashtra retains his powers as king of Hastinapura.

Duryodhana (dhu-ri-yo-dhan-aa)

The crown prince and leader of the Kauravas who maintains this side's alliances. Duryodhana is highly skilled from his training from Balarama, Krishna's brother. Additionally, Duryodhana is seen as a human incarnation of the manifestation of discord and strife, Kali (*deva-gandharva*, not goddess), with bad omens surrounding his birth.

Gandhari (gaan-dhaa-ri)

The self-inflicted blind Queen of Hastinapura with an ability to curse. Her deep penance of covering her eyes to follow Dhritarashtra granted her the power to curse even Krishna himself, as well as the ability to turn flesh invulnerable with a glance. Gandhari, alongside being the Queen, is from the kingdom of Gandhara.

Dushasana (dhu-saash-ana)

The second oldest Kaurava brother, an enforcer whose role is execution and intimidation rather than strategy. Defined by close-combat ferocity and unwavering loyalty, functioning as the regime's instrument of violence.

Vidura (vi-dhu-ra)

The chief minister of the Kuru dynasty court as a human incarnation of Yama due to a curse. His authority derives from divine moral insight rather than force, keeping him as a living embodiment of righteous governance. Vidura is another non-combatant in the war like his half brother, Dhritarashtra, except his non-participation is from a vow to remain neutral.

Shakuni (sha-ku-ni)

Royalty of Gandhara whose influence derives from heavy manipulation, planning, and psychological strategy. Uses deceit and political gamesmanship as weapons to steer state decisions toward conflict. The main conflict regarding the Kurukshetra was spawned from his manipulative dice game.

Dushala (dhu-sha-la)

The only daughter of Dhritarashtra and Gandhari, who has a more diplomatic importance than martial. She represents the maintenance of the Kaurava alliances, kinship politics, and the Kauravas' soft power through marriage ties.

Vikarna (vi-kar-na)

Another Kaurava prince distinguished by his internal moral dissent of his brothers. His significance lies in demonstrating that injustice was recognized internally even as it was carried out. Overall, a more reasonable Kaurava.

Shalya (shal-ya)

King of Madra from the Bahlika clan and a major allied monarch on the Kaurava's side. A skilled warrior and tactician whose strategic influence is amplified through his role as Karna's charioteer. Although, there are some nuances in his involvement in the war. Additionally, Shalya's sister is Madri, wife of King Pandu, the Pandavas' father.

Bhagadatta (buh-guh-duh-tta)

King of Pragjyotisha and great friend of the god Indra who contributes specialized military strength through elephant warfare. Additionally, Bhagadatta was the commander of Chinese and Tibetan tribes in the Kurukshetra.

Jayadratha (jay-ah-dhrath-ah)

The king of Sindhu empowered by a boon granted to him by Lord Shiva to restrain all Pandavas except Arjuna. Additionally, his father had a curse that anyone who brought Jayadratha's head to the ground would have their head exploded into a thousand pieces.

Bahlika (baa-lick-ah)

One of the oldest kings in the Mahabharatha, king of Bahlika and second son of the Lunar Dynasty (Chandravamsha). Bahlika is the brother of King Shanthanu, the progenitor of the Kuru lineage, at least for those present in the Mahabharatha. Classified as an *atirati* (extremely high ranking warrior) by Bhishma, his nephew.

Sudakshina (su-dhak-shi-nah)

King of Kamboja whose strength lies in aggressive battlefield leadership. Represents frontier powers contributing speed, shock tactics, and relentless offense to the Kaurava coalition.

Srutayudha (shru-thaa-you-dha)

King of Kalinga whose sole defining asset is a divine mace gifted by Varuna, allowing him to remain undefeatable so long as the mace is in use. Additionally, Srutayudha is the son of Varuna and river goddess Parnasa.

Susharma (soo-shar-mah)

The king of Trigarta fixated on either killing Arjuna or dying. Leads the Samsaptakas, a terrifying warrior group who swore the same oath regarding Arjuna. Additionally, Susharma has the divine weapon Suparna, an *astra* capable of summoning Garuda, the mount of Lord Vishnu.

Bhishma (bheesh-ma)

The oldest of the Kuru lineage with the divine boon of *iccha mrityu*, allowing him to choose the time of his death. Additionally, Bhishma is one of the greatest warriors in the Kurukshetra, as the supreme commander of the Kaurava side. As a great warrior, Bhishma has access to many *astras*.

Dronacharya (dhro-naa-chaar-ya)

Royal preceptor and teacher of both the Pandavas and Kauravas, known for his mastery over celestial *astras* reserved for divinely sanctioned warriors. His possession and use of such weapons place him among the elite conduits of divine military power.

Ashwatthama (ash-vuth-thaa-ma)

Son of Drona, a master of the mystical arts. Known for the divine gem on his forehead granting him extraordinary powers. His status as a warrior is classified as *Maharathi*. Additionally, Aswatthama is the only person in the Kurukshetra to have access to the *Narayanastra*, a weapon capable of summoning the 11 Rudras and countless weapons to assault a target unless they fully submit.

Kripacharya (kri-paa-chaar-ya)

Immortal warrior and teacher of the Kuru children, identified as a *chiranjivi*, meaning he possesses divine immortality. His power lies in deep martial knowledge, similar to Drona.

Karna (kar-na)

Born with divine armor and earrings, which were later traded to Indra for a single-use divine weapon called the *Vasavi Shakti* that can obliterate any target. His combat role is shaped by direct interaction with gods and irreversible divine bargains. Additionally, he is actually the oldest brother of the Pandavas, with the godly parent of Surya, the sun god, and mother Kunti.

Kritavarma (kri-ta-var-ma)

A Yadava commander of the Narayani Sena, allied to the Kauravas who commanded a portion of the Narayani forces. Represents the transfer of manpower and legitimacy from Krishna's dynasty.

Sanjaya (sun-jay-ahh)

Charioteer and advisor to Dhritarashtra whose power is *divya dhristi*, the power of divine sight that allows him to see events from afar. Additionally, he is a disciple of Sage Veda Vyasa.

Alambusha (ah-lum-bhoo-shah)

Rakshasa ally whose role is nocturnal and supernatural warfare. A representative from the *rakshasas* taking part in the Kurukshetra. Additionally, Alambusha is the brother of the demon Bakasura, retaining similar abilities.

Alayudha (ala-yu-dha)

Rakshasa warrior whose presence escalates night combat through terror and brute force. Alayudha is known for his mastery over illusory powers and he is also Bakasura's brother.

